

Q What is your target for these laptops and where exactly do you want to reach with this partnership with Dell?

We wish to reach out to people who want a simple, easy-to-use, secure computing experience. Frankly, we want to reach out to people who don't care much about operating systems. We are pretty strong already amongst the people who care about operating systems. In the big scheme of the world, people who go to a website, download an operating system and install that on their computers form a relatively small number. This makes our initiative particularly significant because we want to reach out to a whole new audience—the mass consumer audience—and it's important for Ubuntu to sustain our growth, and it's important for companies like Dell and other OEMs as well. We work with others besides Dell, because it helps us bring an open solution to a larger number of people.

Q But there are many challenges as well. The penetration of open source operating systems is pretty low compared to proprietary options like Windows. The trend is global and India is no exception. Ubuntu is not a common name in India. In fact, no Linux-based operating system is common in India. How do you plan to reach out to people who perhaps do not even know the name of your OS, and talk to them about its advantages?

There is not a single trick that will work for this. It is all part of a process. This retail environment is one piece of that puzzle. Think about how people learn about brands in general. They see some media (which may be advertising), they see it around when they walk into the shops, and things like that. People learn about things through their friends or through personal recommendations. Ubuntu is fortunate that we have a very strong advocacy base, a very strong set of users and community which definitely helps spread the word about us.

People also hear about new options in other environments. We do increasingly large desktop deployments in government organisations, in enterprises and in schools. So, an entire generation of children is using Ubuntu as the standard computing environment in schools. That's 'normal' to them as opposed to all of us who probably grew up on a Windows environment. We did not even know that there was any other option. We have very large school deployments in Spain. In India, we have significant education deployments. People are also learning about new technologies. There is an interesting crossover of technology in the sense that people expect to use the same technology at work that they use at home. This is all about the consumerisation of IT and trends. But the reverse also works. People many-a-time take the technology they use in the office to their homes. The management at the workplaces makes this decision for its people, and after they get used to it on their office desktops, they take it to their homes too. We see Ubuntu spreading that way as well. So, there is no simple answer to your question.

There is no multi-million dollar advertising budget that will make Ubuntu a household name all of a sudden. It is something that we have to attack from many angles. One such effort is through our partnership with OEMs. Ubuntu will be available pre-installed in a machine rather than users having to download it. We want to attack through the retail marketing, through services that we provide to the enterprises, and through the Ubuntu community.

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Q After China, you chose India for your retail mission. Why?

Opportunity and growth! India is one of the countries where Ubuntu is most successful and well received. We see significant growth in Ubuntu adoption in India. Over the last year we saw 160 per cent growth. So, we believe that there is real potential and demand here. I would say, again, it is done with partners. So we can go to the market through our OEMs. Canonical is not building computers and Canonical does not have stores. Our OEM partners know the market very well and have much more data than we do about the many machines that ship in India with Ubuntu pre-installed. Our OEM partners believe that we can grow with proper marketing and education.

Q Is there data to support the Ubuntu adoption rates that you just mentioned?

We do not have an exact number. Since Ubuntu is free, we don't ask people to register. We think people should use it out of choice. So, we don't have an exact count of the users, but what we can do is look at the downloads, at security updates and at machines that are shipped with OEMs with Ubuntu pre-installed. When you look at these numbers, what you can get is the general trend and relative growth.

Q Any reasons for choosing Dell as your OEM partner for the first retail expansion in India?

We would like to see Ubuntu in many more retail shops in India and elsewhere. Dell has been a very solid and long-standing partner with Canonical. Both companies saw an opportunity here and invested in that opportunity. But, it is not an exclusive relationship with Dell. We would like to see the same thing happen with other OEMs.

Q So when do we see this relationship extending to other OEMs, and which are the companies that you are looking at?

We already work with many OEMs on various projects. These include Dell, Lenovo, Acer, HP and HCL. Each of